

Hōryū-ji temple and pagoda

The first temple and pagoda at Hōryū-ji in Nara Prefecture was built in 607 CE, soon after Buddhism reached Japan. Struck by lightning in 670, it was rebuilt c.711, and repaired on several occasions. Its perimeter is a covered wooden corridor with an inner gateway (*chumon*) leading into the temple courtyard. Japanese design and architecture emphasizes harmony with nature, and Hōryū-ji, although following Chinese pagodas, focuses on a Japanese understanding of grace, unity and asymmetry.

The complex comprises a five-storey pagoda, the Golden Hall (*kondo*), a free-standing lecture hall (*kodo*), and several small pavilions that were used for housing the sutras, or sacred texts. The pagoda contained symbolic relics of the Buddha, while the Golden Hall was a storehouse of religious images. The pagoda's graceful flaring eaves are supported by cantilevered cloud-pattern bracket arms. With no means to ascend to the upper levels, its function is simply to add decorative height to the overall appearance.

